224 - The Long Way Home

Podcast: secular buddhism

AI Executive Summary

Core Thesis The episode explores how the ancient epic *The Odyssey* serves as a profound metaphor for the Buddhist journey toward enlightenment. The central argument is that while the past and its consequences are unchangeable, our relationship to them is fluid. By applying Buddhist principles—such as non-self, awareness, and radical acceptance—we can transform the "weight" of our history from a haunting burden into a foundational tool for navigating the present moment.

Key Arguments & Data * **The Peril of Numbing (The Lotus Eaters):** The host argues that seeking comfort through "numbing" mechanisms (e.g., social media, substances, or constant busyness) is a danger because it destroys the capacity to feel meaningful pain and joy simultaneously; you cannot numb suffering without also numative the ability to experience what truly matters. * **The Paradox of Identity (The Cyclops):** Using the distinction between Odysseus claiming to be "Nobody" versus "Odysseus, the Sacker of Cities," the host posits that the concept of "non-self" provides freedom and safety, whereas the ego-driven need to assert a fixed identity attracts conflict and destruction. * **The Failure of Control (The Bag of Winds):** Attempting to contain all external variables to prevent hardship (symbolized by the bag of winds) is futile; furthermore, the host highlights that internal "poisons" like greed and suspicion are often what cause these controlled systems to fail. * **Awareness as an Antidote (Circe):** The host claims that unexamined appetite transforms humans into "pigs" (dehumanized by instinct), and that awareness is the only "herb" capable of protecting one's humanity from being consumed by impulse. * **The Utility of Death (The Underworld):** Contemplating mortality (as seen in Odysseus's journey to the land of the dead) is not a morbid exercise but a practical tool to reorder priorities and recognize the inherent preciousness of life. * **Managing Intense Craving (The Sirens):** There are three responses to intense temptation: avoidance (plugging ears), surrender (jumping overboard), or presence (listening and naming the craving without acting). The latter—naming the desire—is presented as the most skillful Buddhist practice. * **The "Second Arrow" of Suffering (Scylla and Charybdis):** In situations where every choice involves loss, wisdom lies in

choosing the path of least harm and accepting it, thereby avoiding the "second arrow"—the self-inflicted mental anguish caused by resisting reality. * **The Value of Impermanence (Calypso):** The host argues that a life without end (immortality) lacks value; preciousness is derived specifically from the fact that moments, people, and lives are fleeting. * **Patience as Active Labor (Penelope):** True patience is not passive waiting or resignation, but the deliberate, daily act of tending to one's responsibilities even when no visible progress is being made. * **The Evolution of History (The Oar):** The episode concludes that we should not attempt to discard our past (the oar), but rather carry it until we reach a state of perspective where its meaning shifts from a heavy, traumatic weapon to a useful tool for the present.

Actionable Takeaways * Practice "Naming" during Craving: When experiencing intense impulses or distractions, use the technique of naming them (e.g., "I am experiencing a craving for X"). This creates the distance necessary to observe the emotion without being compelled to act on it. * **Audit Your "Lotus" Habits:** Identify the specific behaviors you use to numb discomfort (scrolling, substances, etc.) and consciously practice "feeling" the underlying pain rather than suppressing it. * **Adopt the "Least Loss" Strategy in Crises:** When faced with unavoidable difficult decisions, stop searching for a perfect, painless solution. Instead, identify the most skillful path that minimizes loss and practice radical acceptance of that outcome to avoid secondary suffering. * **Reframe Your Past Burdens:** Instead of trying to "undo" or forget past traumas, look for ways to carry them until they can be repurposed as lessons or foundations (the "oar into a farm tool" approach).

Full Transcript

The Secular Buddhism podcast is now on EightfoldPath.com. With transcripts, AI chat, and more, visit EightfoldPath.com. Hello and welcome to another episode of The Secular Buddhism podcast. This is episode number 224. I'm your host, Noah Rochetta. And today I'm going to talk about some of the lessons I think we can learn from the Odyssey. Keep in mind you don't need to use what you learned from Buddhism to be a Buddhist. You can use what you learned to simply be a better whatever you already are. Alright, you're probably thinking, why are we talking about the Odyssey? Well, last night I saw the new movie, The Odyssey, by Christopher Nolan and I really liked it. I had studied the Odyssey in school many years ago. Probably a lot of us did and I hadn't really thought about it since, but I loved the movie and before going to the movie I revisited the storyline and then after the movie did a deep dive again into the original story and as I revisited these stories I kept having this experience where I would think to myself, wow this correlates really well with the teaching of the second arrow or this correlates with the parable of the raft or This is a beautiful way to represent the concept of no self, etc. Because here you have this story that's almost 3,000 years old, written centuries before the Buddha was even born. And it describes the very ideas that I've spent the last 10 years exploring on the podcast through a Buddhist lens. And I think it's worth reflecting on these stories.

because stories, particularly these ancient stories, these are epic stories that are not just Greek stories, they're not just stoic lessons. These are human lessons. These are the stories of humanity, the stories that are passed down across generations to teach ideas, right, to pass along a lesson of some sort, very much like Aesop's fables. and the tortoise and the hare or something along those lines. And I think these are very human lessons, very powerful lessons. And I want to talk about these through the Buddhist lens, through the Buddhist perspective. And again, just like with the tortoise and the hare or any story that I share on here, it doesn't matter if this really happened or not.

The point of the story is what is the teaching that we can extract from it? The Odyssey is a poem originally written by Homer. It's a classic. It's long. And it's been translated and interpreted in different ways. And off of these translations, they've made films, including this most recent one by Christopher Nolan. It's a great film. I really enjoyed it. If you are afraid of spoilers, I'm going to talk about the story itself, not necessarily the film. But the film, as all films tend to do, took creative liberty to condense some of the story and blend things to make it work and fit within the time frame of a movie. So I would say if you're afraid of spoilers, go watch it first, then come back. If you're the kind of person who's like, I want to know all the details, it'll make me appreciate the movie even more.

then listen to this and then go watch the movie. And again, I'm presenting the lessons and the stories from the poem version rather than from the movie. And yet there are aspects of the movie that presented things in a perspective that I really liked and I'll share those as well. So one of the things I have not been able to stop thinking about since watching the movie is the overall theme. that I see in the movie, and it's the theme I want to run through this whole episode, is the fact that the movie presents Odysseus as a man who's haunted by his own greatest victory. If you recall the story of Odysseus and the story of Troy, Odysseus is the person who came up with the idea of leaving the horse.

the Trojan horse, the famous Trojan horse. The giant statue of a horse and the soldiers were hidden inside. And that was the trick that ended a 10-year war. They had been there fighting for 10 years. They were not making progress. And Odysseus has this idea and says, let's make it look like we're done and we're leaving and we'll leave behind a gift. And the gift is a giant statue of a horse. It was probably the most clever thing that he ever did. And it worked. The Trojans bring the horse into the city. And then at night, the soldiers sneak out of the horse and go open the gate. And that's how they're finally able to enter the city of Troy and conquer it. So that victory also becomes his wound. And it's his wound because he realizes the tremendous cost that his trickery or his grand idea You know, came at the cost of what happened to the people inside the city once the gates were open. And you watch the film depict his journey spending 10 years trying to get home and you realize the reason he can't get home has less to do with

the obstacles he's encountering or the sea itself. It has more to do with what he's carrying. Because the thing is, the past can't be undone. It can only be carried. And I think all of us know something about that. Maybe it's not war, but it's a decision that was made. And it was made in a way that made complete sense at the time. And that decision set something in motion. And we've had to live with what was set in motion ever since. And that's how it works. The past is fixed. We don't get to change it. We don't get to go back. But our relationship to the past is not fixed. That can change.

And that's really the whole point of this episode. So I want to walk through 12 lessons from the Odyssey in the order that they happen on the voyage. So if you never read it, all you really need to know about the overall story is this is a story of a man who leaves home to fight in a long war. The war finally ends and it takes him 10 years to get back home because everything in the world and everything inside himself is getting in the way. And one thing I find kind of fascinating is that Homer starts the story in the middle of the mess, not at the beginning. And that's exactly how life works for us when we encounter Buddhist practice, right? We wake up mid voyage, we're living a life mid voyage already blown off course and And now we're like, okay, well, now what do I do? And that's usually when we encounter teachings, teachings like Buddhism or teachings like the lessons that we can extract from the story of the Odyssey. So the same way that Homer starts the story in the middle, we're going to start there too. So early in the journey, the crew trying to make their way home, they land on an island where people eat a flower called the lotus.

And the people there are gentle. They don't attack anyone. They just offer sailors that special fruit. And the sailors who eat it, it removes all the pain of the war, all of their feelings of being homesick, all of that fades. But along with it, something else fades. They lose all desire to go home. And Odysseus has to physically drag his men back to the ships. while they're weeping and crying. They don't want to leave. And that's the effect of the lotus. And here's what I find fascinating about this. Of all the dangers in this overall story, and there are many, there are monsters and storms and giants, the first danger here is the danger of comfort. The lotus doesn't hurt anyone, and that's the trap. It just quietly dissolves their memories and their longing for things that actually matter.

And I think we all have our own version of the Lotus. It can be our phone. It can be social media scrolling through an entire evening. For some it could be the drink or the second drink or the bottle as they say. It could be staying busy, staying so busy that we never have to feel anything because how can I feel anything? I'm busy all the time. And none of these things directly attack us. but they just soften everything. And I think life can suddenly go by like that. And the thing is that numbing is not peace. And I've said before meditation, for example, as a tool is not about feeling good, it's about being good at feeling. So the pain of the war and the longing for home are somewhat the same sensitivity. And you can't numb one without numbing the other. So the lesson in that part of the story is you've got to face the thing that you're actually facing. It's not going to be helpful to try to numb it. Next, on their journey, they land on the island of the Cyclops, the one-eyed giant. And this might be my favorite lesson from the entire story and it's not depicted in the movie. So Odysseus and his men get trapped in the giant's cave. All of that is in the movie, but the details that I'm about to share are not in the movie. The giant is eating the humans, eating the crew, and it eats them two at a time, then it falls asleep. So while it's asleep, that's how Odysseus comes up with a trick to try to escape. And the giant asks him his name. And he says, my name is nobody. And that's what everyone calls me. And then through the story, again, in the poem version, they get the giant drunk and then blind him by taking a sharpened steak, a sharpened steak.

and stabbing his eye. So the giant screams for help and there are other giants that come running and they're asking, who's hurting you? And the giant yells back, nobody, nobody is hurting me. So then the other giants shrug and they go home. And that's how Odysseus and his men escape. And it's a trick that worked pretty well. And once they're on the ship and they're sailing away, this is the part that I think is so... interesting and correlates well with Buddhism. Here, Odysseus can't help himself. He stands on the deck and he shouts back at the island. If anyone asks, who blinded you? Tell them it was Odysseus, the Sacker of Cities. And again, this is in the poem version. It's not in the movie. So he gives his name. He gives his title. And the giant turns out to be a son of Poseidon. And Poseidon, God of the Sea.

decides, well, I'm gonna take my revenge and you hurt my son, so I'm not gonna let you get home. That's actually what sets the whole dilemma on the sea, encountering storms and ultimately that one moment of bragging and trying to take claim of who is it that did this, it costs him 10 years to get home. And if you think about this for a minute, this is the part I liked. It was being nobody is what saved him. And then suddenly the need to be somebody and to make sure that the giant knew who he was, that's what nearly destroyed him. And I just find that fascinating in the original story that being able to be nobody is what saved him. So again, through the Buddhist lens, this is one of the central teachings, the concept of non-self, the idea that the fixed solid somebody that we walk around defending is more like a story than it is a thing. And when we loosen our grip on the story, the story that we have of ourselves, we're not less safe. We're actually just more free. And that whole scene in the story proves it. Nobody is who escapes. It's somebody who then gets in trouble. The next lesson.

comes from the poem as well. It's not in the movie. And this is a heartbreaking scene for the whole story, if you think about it, because here the keeper of the winds gives Odysseus a gift. It's a leather bag that contains every wind that could blow him off course. And it's all sealed up in a bag with only the homeward wind left free in the world. So the homeward wind is going to drive him home. And he doesn't have to worry about these other winds. They're they're safe in the bag. So for nine days, Odysseus steers the ship. He doesn't want to sleep because he's intent to get home. And he's close. He's close enough on the tenth day he can see Ithaca, the city that he's from. He's close enough to see the smoke from from the fires on the beach. And at that point, he's so exhausted, he's finally feels like, OK, it's safe to fall asleep. So he closes his eyes thinking I've essentially made it. I'm going to take a quick nap. It's at that moment that the crew starts whispering, what do you think he has in that bag? Oh, it's probably gold that he is keeping for himself. So they get greedy and they open the bag when they're within sight of home. They're almost home. And then every storm wind explodes at once out of the bag and that blows the ship all the way back to where they started.

So I think there are two lessons here. The first is about control. There's the Zen poet named Ikkyu, who has a line I really like. He says, if it rains, let it

rain. If the wind blows, let it blow. And the bag of winds is what happens when we try the opposite approach. When we try to capture every wind that could possibly go against us, and let's just put it in a bag, we do this all the time. And then the bag... eventually for one reason or another always opens. And then the second lesson out of that is what opened the bag. It wasn't a monster. It was human suspicion and craving on his own ship within sight of the finish line. After years of effort, all of that was undone in one moment of craving, one moment of greed. In our own lives, we encounter the same situation. The journey is going really well and that one moment of craving, or if you think about it through the lens of the three poisons, that one moment of poison affecting our decision-making process can undo the progress that we've made on the journey, and suddenly it sets you back. I just think there's something beautiful in understanding that, because we're never going to get rid of our cravings and desires. That's not it.

It's when we understand them, and we know our patterns really well, then you can experience a moment where you recognize, wow, I am really curious. I want to see what's in that bag, but I can also see I'm almost home. I'm just going to wait till we get home. You can make more skillful decisions when you fully understand your patterns and your cravings. The fourth lesson comes from a character named Sertzi and This is the there's an island that belongs to a sorceress named Sertzi when the scouting party arrives she welcomes them in and she feeds them a feast and then Using her powers she turns them into pigs and the detail that I think is interesting here is It's a human in a in a pig body, but with a human mind. So the pigs are outside But they're actually human. They know. In other words, they're aware of what's happening. And of course, they're very upset because now they are pigs stuck in a pig pen. So Odysseus comes to rescue them. And on the way in the poem, he's given an herb that makes him immune to the spell. And the idea here is pretty simple. Unexamined appetite transforms us. And what is the herb that's the antidote to that?

The way I understand it, I think that herb is awareness, awareness itself. Appetite only transforms us when we're not watching it operate. It's the unawareness that makes it dangerous. Then the story does something pretty crazy because here, Cersei tells Odysseus that the way home is going to require him going through the land of the dead, not around it, through it.

And I think there's something true in that, that you cannot find your way home while you're avoiding death. In the underworld, he meets Achilles, the greatest warrior. Odysseus says, well, surely you rule here among the dead. And Achilles cuts him off and says, I would rather be a normal worker hired by a poor man on a farm than to be here ruling as king of all the dead.

And I thought that was a neat line, because being alive, that was the treasure, but we don't really see that until it's gone. And in Buddhist practice, there's a tradition of deliberately contemplating death, and it's not to be morbid, but it's because thinking of death reorders the priority of what matters. One of the five remembrances is simply, I am of the nature to die. And every time I sit with that in complete honesty, All the trivial stuff changes, right? All the ordinary stuff starts to glow a little bit. So Odysseus goes down to the land of the dead to learn the path to get home. And what he actually learns is why home matters. And then we come to the most famous scene in the story. And I think it's a really practical one. It's the song of the sirens. And if you recall here, the sirens.

are like mermaids, they're creatures whose song is so beautiful that no sailor who hears it can survive. And they steer the ship toward the voices and then the ship will break apart on the rocks, or sailors will jump out of the boat and drown on their way to the rocks. So Odysseus had been warned in advance to not heed the call of the sirens. And the solution is pretty simple. The crew is just going to plug their ears with wax. But Odysseus doesn't want to do that for himself. He wants to hear the song, so he tells his men to tie him up to the mast of the ship. That way, as they sail past, he can hear the song of the sirens and he'll hear every note, but he can't get out of the boat. And it's like a torturous scene in the movie. And in the movie, I like how it's depicted where the song of the sirens, it's not a...

It's not a song that confuses you or disorients you. It's the song that is telling you exactly what you want to hear. It's almost like it's the song that fuels craving to make it so intense that you can't resist. So you chase after the thing you're craving and that's why you get out of the boat and go drown. I think that's a really neat way to think of it. And the reason that this matters is because there are three possible relationships with a powerful craving.

Yes, you can plug your ears and ignore it. That's avoidance. Sometimes that is the right tool, and that's what the crew needed in the film. You can give in to it, jump off the side of the boat and head toward the sound. In the stories, that's always a bad choice because that's what gets you killed. But then there's this third option. To be able to feel the pool completely, to listen to the song, Understand what it's saying and why you're feeling what you're feeling when you hear it, but also to not act on it, to not obey it. That's the practice, and in the stories about the Buddha, there's a character named Mara, and he's like the personification of temptation and distraction, and the Buddha never fights him. He just says, I see you Mara. He names what's happening, and it's the naming that takes the power out of it.

You know, in the Buddhist tradition with Mara, these temptations can come and they can be intense, like the song of the siren, but what takes away that power is naming it. And that's what the Buddha does. He says, I see you, Mara. I know what you're doing. So with the sirens, the craving, it gets to sing its entire song, but that doesn't mean you have to act on it. And I think that's what we discover in our own journeys. Craving is never going to go away. Every craving feels permanent while the song is singing, but none of them are they they come and they go And one more detail that I don't want to leave out. Do you know what the sirens actually sing? It's not pleasure that they're offering again they sing come to us because we know everything that you want and You will get everything that you want. So the temptation there is certainty Isn't that crazy to think about some of us?

are some of us aren't tempted by a specific thing, like indulgence. What we're really tempted by, if you think about it, is the need to know, to have everything resolved. That's part of the siren's song. Over here, you get certainty. Okay, next, Odysseus has to sail through a narrow strait. It's on the side, there's a cliff where there's a six-headed monster, and On the other side, there is a whirlpool that swallows ships. And Odysseus was told, hey, when you get to this place, you're going to have to choose metaphorically between a rock and a hard place. That's actually where the expression between a rock and a hard place comes from. And here, the advice that he was given was when you get there, go along the cliff. You're going to lose six of your...

of your men because the six-headed monster, each head's going to eat one person. But the alternative is the whirlpool and you lose everyone. All of you die. And so he has to make that choice. So he decides to go along the cliff and he loses six of his men. And it's a very difficult moment for him because he feels responsible for it. And yet at the same time, his decision spared everyone else. And here's the thing, sometimes life presents us with choices where every option involves loss. And we torture ourselves because we're searching for which path will ensure no loss at all or no difficulty. But the wisdom in this particular scene and in the story is the honest admission that sometimes there isn't one. And wisdom here isn't finding a way to experience no loss, here the wisdom is, I need to make the choice that is the most skillful, that has the least amount of loss. And I have to do that on purpose because the alternative might be greater loss. And I think that correlates well with the teaching of the second arrow. The first arrow is pain itself, but the second arrow is the pain that we add by resisting and arguing with reality.

Here he had to make the choice between the rock and the hard place. And that's the pain of what had to be done. And then he gets through that and just has to say, well, that's what had to happen. The second arrow of pain would be the pain that you experience thinking, had I just done something else? But there was nothing else to be done. The eighth lesson comes from the... a warning that he had received on an island, the cattle of the sun. Odysseus is told, whatever you do when you get to that island where the cattle of the sun god, don't leave the cows alone. If you harm the cows, you will die. Anyone who kills the cow will die. So they land on this island. The winds turn and they're stranded on this island for a long time.

and the men were warned, and still at some point they just can't resist. They're looking around thinking, you know, if we're gonna die, we can die from starvation right now, or die later on this journey, because that's what we were told would happen. We'll take the risk, and we're not gonna starve now. So they kill the cow, and sure enough, that angers the gods. what I think is interesting about this, again, is the topic of craving. In that moment, clearly, the unskillful choice is to succumb to your craving, to your hunger. And at the moment, it sounds like logic, right? It's like, what Wanting does is it shows up with the costume of being reasonable, and somehow we're

always able to way what comes out in the decision-making as the skillful thing. It's like justifying the purchase that we're talking ourselves into or the message that I probably shouldn't have sent, but I did. It's like we use our intellect and our reasoning to justify the unskillful choice we're about to make. And I think that's the lesson in this one that we need to pay attention.

opens the entire poem by saying, these men died through their own recklessness. And early in the story, Zeus himself complains that mortals blame the gods for their suffering, and yet they bring so much of it on themselves. And that's Homer 3,000 years ago. Again, and honestly, this is about as clean a description of karma as I've ever heard, because karma In the way I understand it, it's not, it never was cosmic justice. It's just this. If I do something, something will happen. It's cause and effect. And the consequences don't care how good our reasons sounded at the time. And I think that's just the nature of reality. I think it correlates well with the old story where the Buddha and his monks encounter a farmer.

who's frantic because his cows have run off. And after the farmer runs off searching, the Buddha turns to the monks and says, do you know why you are the happiest people on earth? Because you have no cows to lose. You remember I did a podcast episode on that called No Cows, No Problems? Here, you had that lesson. No cows, no problems. And Homer's sailors died because they couldn't leave the cows alone. I just think that's a pretty funny correlation. Okay, the ninth lesson is about Calypso So here this is a pretty devastating Part of the story because after the shipwreck after losing everyone Odysseus washes up alone on the island of a goddess named Calypso and she falls in love with him and she keeps him there for seven years and her island is Paradise and at some point she makes him the biggest offer that that anyone makes in the story. Stay with me, and you'll be immortal. You won't age, you won't die, no more storms, no more grief. And if you think about that, that offer, what's on the table here? This is the end of impermanence itself. Everything painful. Aging, sickness, loss, death. She's offering to remove it all permanently. And Odysseus says no. He sits on the beach and he weeps, looking toward home.

And his honesty is what gets me. He doesn't pretend that his wife compares to the goddess. He says, I know she's mortal. She's aging. She will fade.

And you never will. And I never will if I stay here. But even so, I long to be home. So he chooses the life that ends. The aging body, the aging wife, a mortal son. the dog that's going to die, the years that run out. He chooses all of that over paradise. And the way I read it, that's not a sacrifice he's making. That's the insight. Because a life with nothing at stake has nothing precious in it. It's like I've talked about time and the moments that what makes a moment precious is the uniqueness of it. The fact that it will never be again and permanence is what makes it so.

precious and unique. The preciousness of the people that we love is not separate from the fact that, yes, we will lose them. It's the same fact. Impermanence isn't the flaw in this whole deal. Impermanence is what makes the deal worth taking. Odysseus recognizes that. Odysseus looks at forever and he chooses mortality. He chooses an ordinary, impermanent day and life with the people that he loves. He wants to get back to his family. And I think that might be the most Buddhist moment written in this whole storyline. Then the 10th lesson is about Penelope, his wife. So while all this is going on at sea, there's a whole nother journey that's going on at home, and it's his wife Penelope. Her husband's McGon at this point for almost 20 years. Everyone assumes he's dead.

her house is filled up with suitors who are trying to convince her to marry one of them and meanwhile they're camping in her hall eating her food and she tells them I'll choose one of you as soon as I finish weaving this burial shroud and she's weaving it all day but every night when they're not watching she unravels the work she had done for the day trying to prolong this whole or delay this whole experience. So she's always weaving and then unweaving. And to anyone watching, it looks like no progress at all. And that no progress is her holding her entire world open, trying to buy time. And you see, we tend to think of patience as passive, like sitting there and doing nothing, gritting your teeth while waiting. But if you look at her, her patience was very much a deliberate action. It was a daily act, something that she was doing with her hands and no evidence that it would ever pay off. And I've come to think that that's probably what real patience is. It's continuing to tend what you love when nothing visible seems to be improving. Anyone who's cared for a child or for an aging parent knows this and I think it's the same with certain tasks that we do, the patience of

washing the dishes, for example, knowing the dishes are never going to be permanently done. So we wash them anyway. It's an ongoing process. And I've said that before, that patience is an action. It's not resignation. Meanwhile, Odysseus finally gets home and he doesn't march right up to the palace announcing himself. He comes disguised as a beggar into his own house.

And the suitors are there. They're mocking him at his own table. He just takes it all. He watches. He's paying attention. Who's loyal? Who's not? And at night, Lyon awakened his own doorway. He talks to his own heart. And he says, endure my heart. You have endured worse than this. And I love that line. There's the past showing up one more time. And look what he's doing with it now. Because the same history that haunts him is also the proof that Hey, I can do this. I can withstand this. I've been through worse. It's the same past, but a different relationship to it. The record of what we've survived can be the weight that we drag with us now, or it can be the very teacher that gave us the foundation of a lesson that we now stand on. It's the same thing. It's the same past, different relationship to it.

The eleventh lesson is about the city Ithaca and the fact that there's no going back. So he finally makes it 20 years. He's finally standing on Ithaca and and it's the realization that Nothing is the way he left it His mother's dead his son who's a baby is now a grown man that he doesn't even know and there's this really touching moment depicted in the movie with his old dog Argos who was a puppy when he left. And Argos is just laying there neglected in the yard. Nobody recognizes the beggar. Nobody knows it's actually Odysseus. But the dog does. And the dog knows him, wags his tail and then dies because he's really old. And that moment was really tender. It was really sad, but also very touching because, again, the loyalty of a dog. And the man who left doesn't exist anymore, right? This is where the movie I think really resonates for me because the film understands that this isn't a homecoming in the simple sense. It's a reckoning. He doesn't get to resume his old life because that life is gone and the man he was is also gone. What he gets to do is meet what's actually here as who he actually is now. So coming home doesn't mean going back.

because there is no going back. There's only ever arriving in the present moment. And there's a Zen saying that I've shared before about a broken mirror never reflecting again. Flowers that fall never get to go back to the branch. And I used to think of that as kind of sad, but I don't anymore. It's just an accurate depiction of reality. Every one of us has our Ithaca. that thing of the past that we're trying to get back to, some version of normal that we're hoping to get back to. For some, it might be the body I once had before or the relationship I once had before or the family before, before loss. And the honest news is you can't go back to how things were. Okay, the last lesson, you'd think the story ends here, but there's one more lesson when When Odysseus gets home, Homer wrote that all the movies leave this out. And I think it might be the greatest lesson of all. In the underworld, Odysseus was given one final instruction, something he has to do when he gets home. He says, you have to take an ore, the ore from the ship, put it on your shoulder and walk inland, away from the sea. And you keep walking however long it takes until...

until he reaches people so far from the ocean that they don't know what an oar is. They've never seen a ship. Until the day that a traveler looks at the oar on his shoulder and asks, what is that, a farming tool? It's at that moment that he can take the oar, plant it in the earth, make an offering to Poseidon, the very God who spent 10 years trying to prevent him from getting home, and then go home. will ensure he gets to experience a gentle death far from the sea in peaceful old age. And I want to sit with that image for a minute because the ore is the tool of his whole journey. It's the symbol of everything the sea did to him and everything he did on that ship. And the instruction isn't hang the ore on the wall as a relic. It's not throw it away or burn it or never speak of it.

The instruction is carry it. Carry it so far and so long that you finally arrive somewhere where it doesn't mean what it used to mean. Where the weapon of your past looks to to fresh eyes like something that might be used for farming and there plant it and make peace with what you can't undo. And the Buddha told a story that I come back to over and over about a man who builds a raft across a river and On the far shore, the man thinks that, well, this raft saved my life. Should I continue to carry it forever? And the Buddha asks, is that what the raft is for? The raft was for crossing over.

Like, should you continue to carry it? And this is a similar message, except it's different in the sense that Homer wrote the same teaching. But he was honest about the fact that sometimes you can't leave the raft there on the other shore. Sometimes Some of the things that we carry, we're not able to set them down the moment that we want to or that we're told to. And in this case, the ore has to be carried inland for years. And carrying it beyond the shore isn't a failure. Carrying it is how it changes. You carry the past until the day that it stops being an ore. I just think there's something so beautiful and symbolic in that part of the story. Because that's the day you can plant it.

and say, I no longer need to carry this with me. And notice the journey doesn't actually end at the homecoming because even Ithaca isn't the finish line. As I've said before, you can get there and then what? You keep going because the path itself is the goal. So coming back to where we started, the past can't be undone. It can only be carried. What's done is done, but our relationship to the past is not fixed. The same history can be a haunting or it can be a teacher. It can be a weight that we drag or it can be the lesson that becomes the very ground that we stand on. The ore can remain an ore or it can resemble a farm tool and it's not because the past changed it's because the person and the world changed and whatever we're each carrying because we're all carrying something The invitation is not to try to undo what's been done. The invitation is to keep walking with it, awake until we reach the place where we can plant what we've been carrying and we no longer need to carry it. And we don't have to sail the ocean for 10 years to learn this lesson. The lesson is quite simple is that here we are in the present moment and nothing is missing from this moment.

home is wherever we already are. And that's what I wanted to share with you. I hope you enjoy the movie as much as I did. That's all I've got for this episode. Thank you for listening. Until next time. Thank you for listening to the Secular Buddhism podcast. If you'd like to read the full transcript of this episode, explore guided meditations, or just take a deeper dive into the teachings, visit eightfoldpath.com. There you'll find transcripts, courses, and NOAAI, a tool that lets you chat directly with all of my content. Whether you have a single question about today's episode or want to

explore over a decade of teachings, it's all there. Visit 8foldpath.com to learn more.